

Session 16: The Waters Above and Below

Key Takeaways

- In the Bible, water can be life-giving (streams, rivers, rain) or deadly (the flood waters, the sea, the deep).
- The waters above the *raqia'* are not the source of normal rain but of the flood, mirroring the dark waters below (Gen. 7:11).
- The waters below, or the *tehom* (the deep), are chaotic waters often synonymous with death or the pit (*Sheol*).

The Cosmology of Genesis 1 and the Narrative World of the Bible

The waters above the sky are not the source of rain, but they are a heavenly mirror of the dark waters below the land. The “many waters” above are the source of the flood.

Genesis 1:6-8 Instructor's Translation

⁶ Then God said, “Let there be a dome in the midst of **the waters**, and let it separate the waters from **the waters**.” ⁷ God made the dome, and separated **the waters**, which were below the dome from **the waters which were above the dome**; and it was so. ⁸ God called the dome heavens/skies. And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

Genesis 7:11 NRSV*

In the six hundredth year of Noah’s life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on the same day all the fountains of the great deep burst open, and **the windows of the skies** were opened.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 8:1-3 NASB*

¹ But God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the cattle that were with him in the ark; and God caused a wind to pass over the earth, and the water subsided. ² Also the fountains of the deep and **the windows of the skies** were closed, and the rain from the sky was restrained; ³ and the water receded steadily from the earth, and at the end of one hundred and fifty days the water decreased.

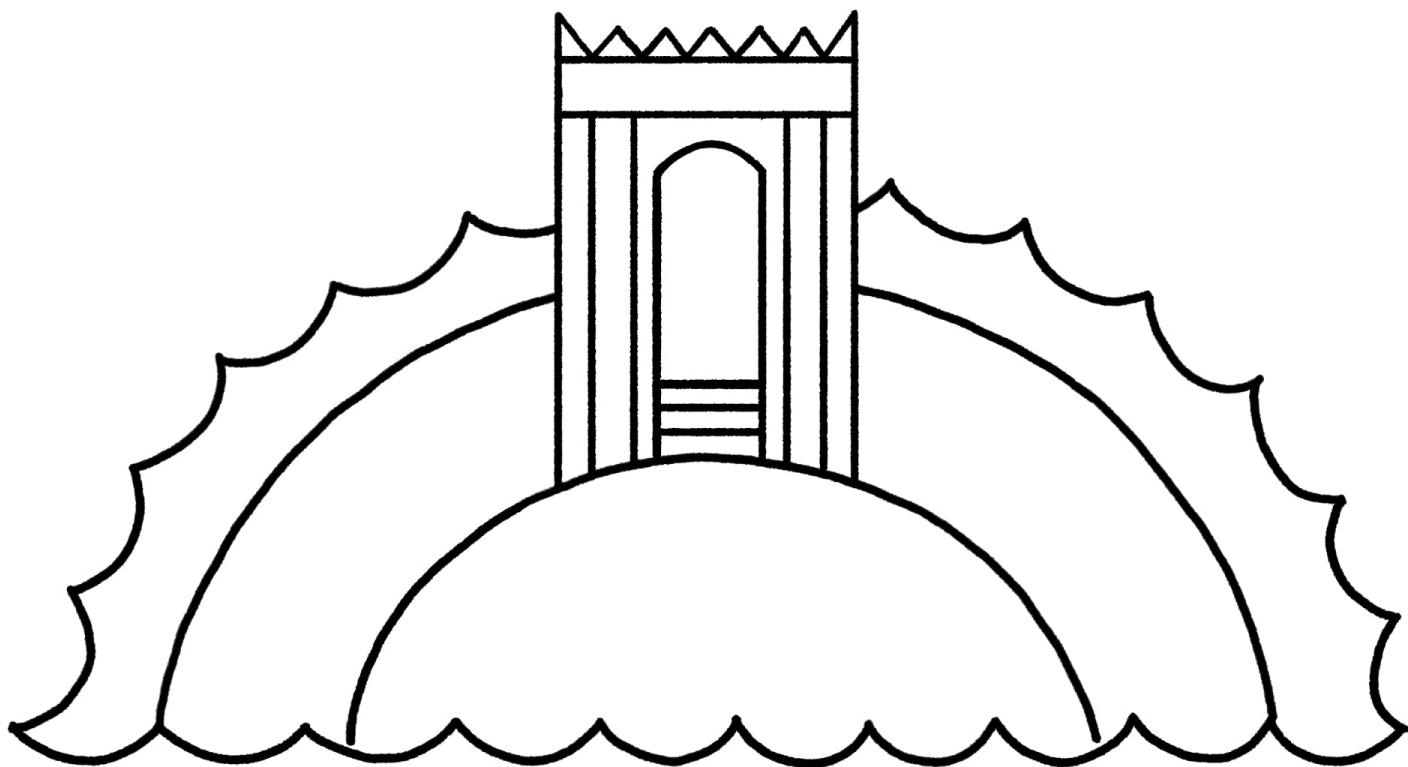
*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 104 and 148 are poetic explorations of the cosmology of Genesis 1, summoning every tier of creation and all their inhabitants to praise the Creator.

Psalms 104:1-3 NASB*

¹ Bless the LORD, O my soul!
O LORD my God, you are very great;
you are clothed with splendor and majesty,
² covering yourself with light as with a cloak,
stretching out heaven like a tent curtain.
³ He lays the beams of his upper chambers in the waters;
he makes the clouds his chariot;
he walks upon the wings of the wind ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher



The Temple as a Portal. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Psalm 148:1-6 NASB*

¹ Praise the LORD!
Praise the LORD from the heavens;
praise him in the heights!
² Praise him, all his angels;
praise him, all his hosts!
³ Praise him, sun and moon;
praise him, all stars of light!
⁴ Praise him, highest heavens,
and the waters that are above the heavens!

⁵ Let them praise the name of the LORD,
for he commanded and they were created.

⁶ He has also established them forever and ever;
he has made a decree which will not pass away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Many texts describe the “great waters above” that Yahweh sits above on his heavenly throne (Jer. 10:12-13; Ps. 29:3, 10; Ps. 104:1-3).

These cosmic heavenly waters are different from the rain released by the clouds, which float below the sky-dome.

Job 26:8 NASB

He wraps up the waters in his clouds, and the cloud does not burst under them.

Psalms 147:7-8 NASB

⁷ Sing to the LORD with thanksgiving; sing praises to our God on the lyre, ⁸ who covers the heavens with clouds, who provides rain for the earth, who makes grass to grow on the mountains.

The water falling from the clouds was viewed as different from the cosmic waters that God holds back with the sky-dome above.

Jeremiah 10:10-13 NASB

¹⁰ But Yahweh is the true God; he is the living God and the everlasting King. At his anger the earth quakes, and the nations cannot endure his indignation. ¹¹ So you shall say to them, “The gods that did not make the skies and the land will perish from the land and from under the skies.” ¹² It is he who made the land by his power, who established the world by his wisdom; and by his understanding he has stretched out the skies. ¹³ When he utters his voice, there is a tumult of waters in the skies, and he causes the clouds to ascend from the end of the earth; he makes lightning for the rain, and brings out the wind from his storehouses.

Psalms 29:3, 9-10 NASB

³ The voice of the LORD is over the waters; the God of glory thunders, the LORD is over the great waters. ⁹ ... And in his temple everything says, “Glory!” ¹⁰ The LORD sits as King at the flood; yes, the LORD sits as King forever.

Reflection Question

In the Bible, water is presented in many forms—sometimes as life-giving streams, rivers, or rain that waters the earth. But what ideas do “the waters above” and “the deep” convey?